

**The Blank Text Strips on the Third Intermediate Period Theban Coffins Applied on an Unpublished Cartonnage at the Egyptian Museum in Cairo (TR. 5.11.16.4).**

شرائط النصوص الفارغة على توابيت طيبة خلال عصر الانتقال الثالث  
تطبيقاً على كارتوناج غير منشور في المتحف المصري بالقاهرة (TR. 5.11.16.4)

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**Abstract:**

This paper discusses and analyzes the potential reasons for the presence of blank text strips as a feature of some Third Intermediate Period Theban coffins, applied on an unpublished cartonnage stored in the Egyptian Museum's basement (TR. 5.11.16.4), characterized by blank text strips running along its entire length. This cartonnage can be dated to the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty according to the typology and criteria of the decorations.

Furthermore, the paper conducts a comparative analysis of twenty-one coffins that feature the same artistic element, dating from the Second Intermediate Period to the Greco-Roman Period.

The study aims to provide a classification of these coffins and suggests various coffin cases that are available for sale in the workshops. It also offers several explanations for leaving text strips blank and what they indicate.

These reasons can be summarized in the hypothesis that workshops were producing ready-made coffins intended for the open market. These coffins were sold and used for burials as they were; some had minimal inscription text strips, mostly on the footboard, while others had blank text strips throughout the coffin. This may have been done to cut costs or for decorative, religious, or practical reasons.

Heavy demand for ready-made coffins arises from their importance and the ongoing necessity for this funerary product to facilitate the journey to the afterlife for all social classes, with the features and price of the coffin adjusted to suit each of these classes.

**Keywords:** Coffin, Cartonnage, Blank text strips, Third Intermediate Period, Thebes, Coffin workshops.

**الملخص:**

تناقش هذه الورقة البحثية وتحلل الأسباب المحتملة لوجود شرائط النصوص الفارغة كسمة لبعض توابيت طيبة خلال عصر الانتقال الثالث، تطبيقاً على كارتوناج غير منشور مخزن في قبو المتحف المصري (TR. 5.11.16.4)، يتميز بأشرطة نصية فارغة تمتد على طوله بالكامل، هذا الكارتوناج يمكن تأريخه بالأسرة الثانية والعشرين، وذلك طبقاً للدراسات التصنيفية وخصائص المناظر، فضلاً عن ذلك، يقدم البحث تحليلاً مقارناً لعدد واحد وعشرين تابوتاً يتسمون بنفس السمة الفنية من عصر الانتقال الثاني إلى العصرين اليوناني والروماني. تهدف الدراسة إلى تصنيف هذه التوابيت، وتقترح الحالات المختلفة للتوابيت وقت البيع في ورش العمل، كما تقدم تفسيرات متعددة لترك شرائط النصوص فارغة وما تشير إليه.

يمكن تلخيص هذه الأسباب في فرضية أن الورش كانت تنتج توابيت جاهزة للسوق المفتوحة. تم بيع هذه التوابيت واستخدامها للدفن كما هي؛ كان بعضها يحتوي على شرائط نصية بسيطة منقوشة في الغالب على مسند القدم، بينما كان البعض الآخر يحتوي على شرائط نصية فارغة بطول التابوت، ربما كان ذلك لخفض التكاليف، أو لأسباب زخرفية، أو دينية أو عملية.

يأتي الطلب الكبير على التوابيت الجاهزة المتوفرة في الأسواق من أهميتها والحاجة المستمرة لهذا المنتج الجنائزي في رحلة العالم الآخر لجميع الطبقات الاجتماعية، مع تعديل سمات وسعر التابوت بما يتناسب مع كل طبقة من هذه الطبقات.

**الكلمات المفتاحية:** تابوت، كارتوناج، شرائط نصية فارغة، عصر الانتقال الثالث، طيبة، ورش صناعة التوابيت.

## **1. Introduction**

Coffins with blank text strips are more complex than commonly perceived, based on a group of coffins with blank strips in the Third Intermediate Period. This paper proposes and discusses the possible reasons for the presence of coffins featuring blank text strips. These reasons can be summarized in the hypothesis that workshops were producing ready-made coffins intended for the open market.

Following this hypothesis, these coffins were typically decorated with contemporary scenes and features relevant to each period, while intentionally leaving the strips of text blank to be filled in by the eventual buyer.

In a not insignificant number of these coffins, the sale process was completed after an important and seemingly quick step: recording the name of the coffin's owner and the title in the usual place on the footboard of most coffins.

To explore these complexities further, this paper studying a painted cartonnage coffin identified by inventory number (TR. 5.11.16.4), currently stored in the museum basement. In addition to this case, the discussion extends to other coffins with blank text strips that are housed in various museums (see Table 1).

Ultimately, the findings will contribute to a deeper understanding of funerary practices and the workings within coffin workshops as well as the steps involved in selling them.

### **1.1 Ready-made coffins production for the open market:**

It seems unlikely that elaborate coffin sets were created during the mummification process; rather, like tombs from earlier periods, they were likely prepared in advance during the lifetimes of their future owners.<sup>1</sup>

Many Late Period coffins were produced through "serial production" and were not custom-made; these were prepared in advance but without specific individualization.<sup>2</sup>

Although the textual materials provide weak evidence about the production of coffins for the open market, such as mentions in workshop record texts within the hieratic ostraca (O. Michaelides 13, 3-4 rt.<sup>3</sup>- O. Brooklyn 37.1880 E., 4-7 vs.<sup>4</sup>- O. Berlin 12343, 4 rt.<sup>5</sup>).

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<sup>1</sup> Sheikholeslami, M., "Sokar-Osiris and the Goddesses: Some Twenty-fifth-Twenty-sixth Dynasty Coffins from Thebes", in: *Thebes in the first millennium BC*, Pischikova, E., Budka, J., Griffin, K., (eds.), London: Golden House Publications, 2018, p. 454.

<sup>2</sup> Niwinski, A., *21st Dynasty Coffins from Thebes, Chronological and Typological Studies*, Theben 5, Mainz am Rhein: Verlag Philipp von Zabern, 1988, p. 55.

<sup>3</sup> A workshop record text from the late 19<sup>th</sup> Dynasty mentions that 2 coffins are said to be "for the mryt riverbank" and thus perhaps meant for the open market or for trade elsewhere; Cooney, K. M., *The value of Private Funerary Art in Ramesside period Egypt*, Ann Arbor,

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There is some archaeological evidence suggesting that craftsmen produced these items directly for unknown buyers, as evidenced by the fact that many funerary objects were finished with a blank space left for the future owner's name.<sup>6</sup>

In this context, (Table 1) provides examples of coffins actually used for burials without any inscriptions (Examples 1-2-3-4-7-8-9-10-11), in addition to the cartonnage under study (TR. 5.11.16.4), in which the deceased was actually buried inside it (fig. 2) without any writing, not even the name of the deceased.

The buyer of these coffins may also be a member of the deceased's family, who died suddenly before buying his coffin, for financial or practical reasons, given the immediate need for it. The family of the deceased may purchase the coffin with the blank text bands and use it for the burial in its current state.

Economic constraints likely played a significant role in the emergence of blank text strips on coffins. Some individuals avoided the costs of hiring a scribe to record their coffin texts, which could cost more than the decoration (average decoration costs 10.5 dbn<sup>7</sup>, compared to 22.75 dbn for texts)<sup>8</sup>.

As a result, this led to three groups for ready-made coffins being identified by their blank text strips. The first group, proposed by the study, featured completely blank text strips along the entire length of the body. For example, Cartonnage under study TR. 5.11.16.4 (figs. 4, 5), Cartonnage A.1911.399.1 B (Table. 1, no. 8), Cartonnage E 13022 (Table. 1, no. 9), and wooden Coffin 39.4042.5b (Table. 1, no. 11).

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MI: UMI, 2002, p.194. For the text see: Goedicke, H., Wente, E. F., *Ostraka Michaelides*, Wiesbaden: Otto Harrassowitz, 1962, p. 17, pl.46.

<sup>4</sup> A workshop record text from the late 19<sup>th</sup> Dynasty mentions some wood that is brought down to a craftsman at the riverbank who can use it; Cooney, *The value of Private Funerary Art*, p.194. For the text see: Kitchen, K.A., *Ramesside Inscriptions*, vol. 7, Oxford: Blackwell, 1989, p. 310-11; Janssen, J. J. *De Markt op de Oever*, Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1980, p.14; McDowell, A. G., *Village Life in Ancient Egypt*, Oxford: Munn & Co., 1999, p. 84-85, no. 55.

<sup>5</sup> A workshop record text from the mid-20<sup>th</sup> Dynasty mentions the decoration of a coffin that is traded for a cloak "in town," presumably in Thebes, but no buyer is recorded. Cooney, *The value of Private Funerary Art*, p.194. For the text see: Kitchen, *Ramesside Inscriptions*, vol. 6, p. 164-65; McDowell, *Village Life*, p. 81-82.

<sup>6</sup> Cooney, *The value of Private Funerary Art*, p. 194.

<sup>7</sup> Deben (weight measure, usually 91 g). For more: Erman A., Grapow H., *Wörterbuch der Ägyptischen Sprache*, vol. 5, Berlin: Akademie-Verlag, 1940, p. 438. 2-10; Leitz, Ch., *Lexikon der ägyptischen Götter und Götterbezeichnungen*, vol. 2, Orientalia Lovaniensia Analecta 111, 2002. col. 1202.

<sup>8</sup> Cooney, *The value of Private Funerary Art*, p. 207-208.

In other cases, the deceased would ask the worker present in the coffin workshop at the time of sale to inscribe certain details, such as the deceased's name and title, which were typically placed on the footboard of the coffin.

As a result, this led to the second group, which featured blank text strips along the body except for the footboard. For example, cartonnage coffin EA30720 (Table. 1, no. 7) and the wooden coffin TR. 1.11.16.7<sup>9</sup>.

If we exclude reusing, the workshop may also produce ready-made coffins for a more advanced class. In these cases, religious texts are written on coffins, accompanied by decoration, with a small space left for the name to be added<sup>10</sup> at the time of sale.

Notably in this case, only a few coffins were used in burials as they are, without the addition of a name. For example, the wooden coffin 14.10.1a, b (Table. 1, no. 2) and JE. 29622 – CG. 6133<sup>11</sup>. This resulted in the third group of ready-made coffins proposed by the study.

## **1.2 Coffin decorative works:**

The first decorative step taken on the coffin, which the carpenter handed over, involved covering all the surfaces designated for painting with a layer of white gesso, using horizontal and vertical lines<sup>12</sup>.

The artist divided the surface into geometric rectangular panels. He already had a complete plan for the decoration and was aware of which scenes would be depicted<sup>13</sup>; in addition, there were strips to then contain texts, most likely from afterlife books,

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<sup>9</sup> Painted Wooden Anthropoid Coffin from Thebes (Al-Asasif excavations, 1916) Preserved in the Egyptian Museum in Cairo, TR 1.11.16.7; Forthcoming.

<sup>10</sup> If the buyer's name was added at the time of sale, this group is difficult to identify. However, it may be possible to distinguish them by analyzing differences in the font features of the added section.

<sup>11</sup> Mostafa, H., "The Outer Coffin Lid of an Anonymous Woman (JE 29622) from Bab El-Gasus" in: *Egyptian Journal of Archeological and Restoration Studies*, Vol.14/1, 2024, pp. 61-69.

<sup>12</sup> Taylor J. H., "Patterns of colouring on ancient Egyptian coffins from the New Kingdom to the Twenty-sixth Dynasty" in: Davies, W. V., *Colour and painting in ancient Egypt*. British Museum Press, 2001, p. 165.

<sup>13</sup> The coffin industry is characterized by standard patterns for coffin colors and arrangement of scenes, according to the artistic features of each period, which makes the artist aware of the final form of the coffin he is making; Taylor, Patterns of colouring on ancient Egyptian coffins, p. 165.

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especially the Book of the Dead, as well as personal data, such as the name and title of the coffin owner and the names and titles of his parents <sup>14</sup>.

As these strips were left blank on some coffins, and some coffins really were sold with blank strips, this indicates that another specialist, the writer, was specifically involved in the final stage of decorating the coffins before selling them according to the buyer's financial capabilities, as filling them would naturally increase the price of the coffins.

The pattern of occurrence of the distinctive paleographical and graphical 'fingerprints' of particular craftsmen suggests that the coffin assemblages were not always produced in distinct, self-contained 'workshops', but rather by a wider pool of painters and scribes who adapted their work to the requirements of the purchaser <sup>15</sup>. Therefore, the price of each coffin differs.

### 1.3 coffin prices:

Cooney proposed a consistent link between the owner's social status and the material richness of his/her burial elements, as manifested chiefly in the number of coffins per person, the materials used, and the content in the coffin iconography <sup>16</sup>. Taylor adds that only the higher elite could afford the services of those craftsmen who possessed (or had access to) sophisticated religious knowledge<sup>17</sup>.

The purchasers of burial assemblages - particularly those with more limited resources - faced a complex series of choices to obtain an acceptable balance between materials, quality of craftsmanship, and efficacious magical content<sup>18</sup>.

Individuals selected the characteristics of their funerary equipment based on several factors. Particularly when resources were limited, their priorities might differ<sup>19</sup>.

Some ostraca provide a list of coffin prices, which vary based on several factors. These factors include decoration, varnishing, color, pigment, the amount of copper

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<sup>14</sup> Niwinski, *21st Dynasty Coffins from Thebes*, p. 56.

<sup>15</sup> Taylor, J. H., Evidence of social patterns in Theban coffins of dynasty 25, in: Taylor, J., Vandenbeusch, M. (eds.), *Ancient Egyptian Coffins. Craft Traditions and Functionality*, British Museum publications on Egypt and Sudan 4, Leuven: Peeters, 2018, p. 373.

<sup>16</sup> Cooney, K. M., "Ancient Egyptian funerary arts as social documents", in: R. Sousa (ed.), *Body, cosmos and eternity. New research trends in the iconography and symbolism of ancient Egyptian coffins*, Oxford: Archaeopress, 2014, p. 48.

<sup>17</sup> Taylor, *Evidence of social patterns in Theban coffins of dynasty 25*, p. 350.

<sup>18</sup> Cooney, K. M., *The cost of death. The social and economic value of ancient Egyptian funerary art in the Ramesside period*, *Egyptologische Uitgaven* 22. Leiden: Nederlands Instituut voor het Nabije Oosten, 2007, p. 256-8.

<sup>19</sup> Cooney, *The cost of death*, p. 257.

used, the craftsmanship quality, the time taken to produce it, and the type of wood chosen for construction<sup>20</sup>.

Additionally, Janssen suggests that the decoration of a man's coffin may be slightly more expensive than that of a woman's<sup>21</sup>.

As a result, the cost of a coffin can be quite high<sup>22</sup>, with most prices typically ranging between 20 and 40 dbn, it may sometimes reach 80 dbn according to the price of one of the coffins in O. Turin 57368, 2-3 rt<sup>23</sup>.

#### **1.4 Cartonnage manufacture:**

The "cartonnage" usually refers to an innermost piece that enveloped the body, and the earliest mummy wrappings to be made of cartonnage were masks placed over the head of the wrapped body. This led to the creation of full-length mummy-shaped coffins<sup>24</sup>. This new element, introduced to Thebes from the north<sup>25</sup> at the beginning of the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty around the reign of Sheshonq II, provided enhanced protection for the body<sup>26</sup>.

Instead of using wood, several layers of textile were glued together to wrap the deceased like a cocoon. This new type of inner coffin was made from readily available materials<sup>27</sup>. Cartonnage continued to be used in the Third Intermediate Period until the early 25<sup>th</sup> dynasty<sup>28</sup>. Then use again in the Ptolemaic and early Roman Periods. Each period produced its own distinct style of cartonnage manufacture and decoration during this period<sup>29</sup>, most people of high status, and many of 'middle' rank, were buried in these periods inside a cartonnage coffin<sup>30</sup>.

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<sup>20</sup> Janssen, J. J., *Commodity Prices from the Ramesside Period: An Economic Study of the Village of Necropolis Workmen at Thebes*, Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1975, p. 217.

<sup>21</sup> Janssen, *Commodity Prices from the Ramesside Period*, p. 266.

<sup>22</sup> Janssen, *Commodity Prices from the Ramesside Period*, p. 223.

<sup>23</sup> Cooney, *The value of Private Funerary Art*, p. 205.

<sup>24</sup> Cooney, K. M., Coffins, Cartonnage, and Sarcophagi, Chapter 14, in: *A Companion to Ancient Egyptian Art*, Hartwig M. K. (ed.), Chichester: Wiley, 2015, p. 272.

<sup>25</sup> Johnston, Kea Marie, *Unseen Hands: Coffin Production at Akhmim, Dynasties 21-30*, PhD diss., University of California, Berkeley, 2022, p.14.

<sup>26</sup> Fitzenreiter, M., *Allerhand Kleinigkeiten, Internet-Beiträge zur Ägyptologie und Sudanarchäologie*, vol. 20, Berlin; London: Golden House Publications, 2018, p. 33.

<sup>27</sup> Hunkeler C., "New results on the manufacture and durability of cartonnage: experimental archaeology as a method to understand the history of 22nd Dynasty cartonnage cases from KV40", in: *Journal of Archaeological Science* 36, 2021, p. 2.

<sup>28</sup> Taylor, *Evidence of social patterns in Theban coffins of dynasty 25*, p. 373.

<sup>29</sup> Adams, C.V.A., The manufacture of ancient Egyptian cartonnage cases, *The Smithsonian Journal of History* 1, 1996, pp. 55- 66.

<sup>30</sup> Taylor, *Evidence of social patterns in Theban coffins of dynasty 25*, p. 373.

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While it was formerly believed that cartonnages dated to the Libyan period were molded over the body of the deceased, it has been determined that many of these shells were produced on an armature. Some cartonnages fit very closely around the mummy, while in others, the body is considerably shorter than the case. This discrepancy occurs because the cartonnage was not molded directly around the body; instead, it was shaped over a disposable core made of mud and straw, which was designed to approximate the average mummy's shape<sup>31</sup>.

The core was then coated with coarse plaster, and several layers of linen soaked in gum were applied, covering it completely except for an opening at the base of the feet. Additionally, a narrow vertical slit was left at the rear<sup>32</sup>. Noting that this was the same way the cartonnage used for the study was made (fig.3).

After the final layer of linen was applied, this rear slit was carefully opened, allowing for the core to be removed in pieces. This process resulted in a hollow mummiform shell made of plaster and gummed linen<sup>33</sup>.

Therefore, the author chose an unpublished cartonnage coffin (Fig. 4) as the first example for studying blank text strips on the Third Intermediate Period Theban coffins, as cartonnage cases could not be opened without being destroyed, which meant they could not be reused for future burials.

As suggested by this study, this cartonnage is available on the open market as Group 1, which is characterized by completely blank text strips that lack any name or title to identify the owner.

The cartonnage owner's mummy, wrapped in linen (TR 5.11.16.4.b), is visible through a fracture in the crown of the head (fig. 1). This is more clearly seen through the underside of the footboard (fig. 2), which is completely missing.



(Fig.1) The crown of the head  
© Egyptian Museum in Cairo.



(Fig. 2) The underside of the  
footboard, © Egyptian Museum  
in Cairo.



(Fig.3) The cartonnage back central  
lacing, © Egyptian Museum in Cairo.

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<sup>31</sup> Elias, J. P., *Coffin inscription in Egypt after the new kingdom: a study of text production and use in elite mortuary preparation*, Ann Arbor, MI: UMI, 1993, p. 332.

<sup>32</sup> Elias, *Coffin inscription in Egypt after the New kingdom*, p. 333.

<sup>33</sup> Elias, *Coffin inscription in Egypt after the New kingdom*, p. 334.



## 2. The unpublished cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4 (fig. 4)



(Fig.4) unpublished Cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4a  
© The Egyptian Museum in Cairo, photo by Mr. Sameh Abdelmohsen.

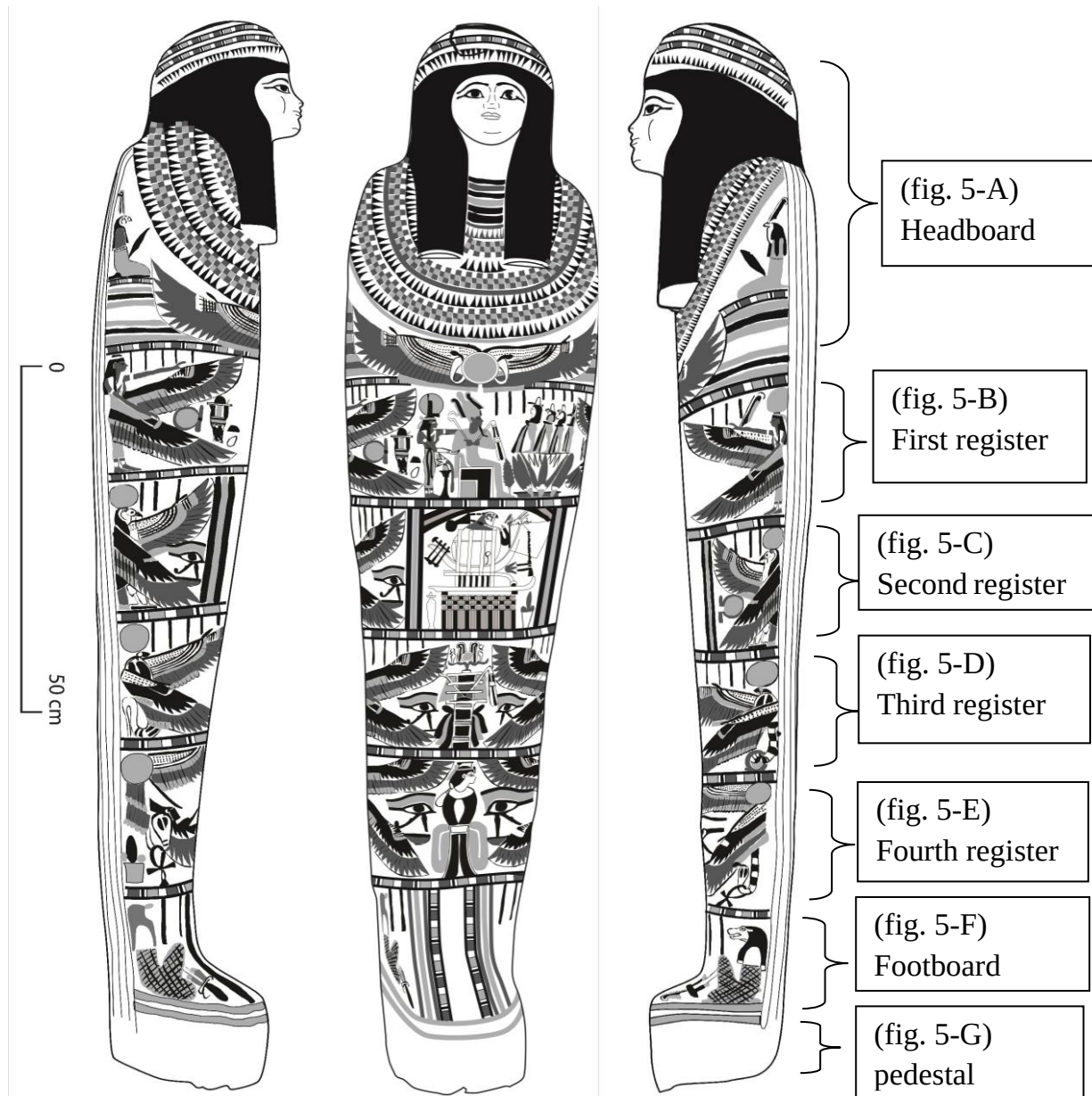
### 2.1 Description of unpublished cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4:

Cartonnage coffin from Sheikh Abd El-Qurna (Excavations 1916) and housed in the basement of the Egyptian Museum in Cairo (TR. 5.11.16.4) dates to the 22<sup>nd</sup> dynasty, according to the typology and criteria of the decorations.

Dimensions: Height: 175.2 cm, Width: 53.5 cm.



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(Fig.5) Facsimile of the unpublished Cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4a  
line drawings by Mr. Ahmed Abd El-Mnaam

### 2.1.1 Headboard: (fig. 5-A)

The face and neck are painted a reddish-brown color. There are no ears, and the eyes are sculpted, painted, and outlined in black, while the mouth displays a faint smile. The deceased was wearing a black tripartite hair wig, which is typical for female coffins from this period. The top of the head is painted black and is left undecorated.

### 2.1.2 Upper section:

The upper section features a wide *Wsh* collar that is designed with layers of geometric shapes, plant petal motifs, and rosettes. The collar did not fill the shoulder,

as on either side of the shoulder was depicted a sitting guardian deity with the head of a snake holding a knife. Beneath the colorful *Wsh* collar, a winged solar deity appears in the form of a solar disc, with two uraei extending outward as it protectively spreads its wings. There is a total of four registers, starting below the collar and extending to the footboard.

#### **2.1.2.1 First register: (fig. 5-B)**

On each side, there are two-winged woman deities that are not identical. The right deity is the smallest and has a sun disc on her head, holding the hieroglyph for Ma'at (truth) in her arms. In the center, there is a vignette that depicts Osiris in mummiform, adorned with the Atef crown and holding a crook and flail in his hands. Behind him stands Isis, and further back is the only word recorded on the cartonnage:  *B3stt*.

While in front of Osiris are the four sons of Horus: Imsety, Duamutef, Qebehsenuef, and Hapy. Each son is depicted in mummiform and has a distinct head: human, falcon, baboon, and jackal heads, respectively. They are all positioned on a lotus flower, symbolizing rebirth.

Additionally, there are eleven vertical yellow strips left blank, probably intended for accompanying text. Typically, these strips would feature the names and titles of gods, as well as the name and titles of the deceased. Noting that the deceased is not depicted in this scene, as she/he is usually shown in the vignette for Spell 125 of the Book of the Dead<sup>34</sup> being led by Horus to Osiris, who is also absent.

#### **2.1.2.2 Second register: (fig. 5-C)**

On each side, there are two-winged falcon deities with a sun disc on their head stretching their wings; between the wings of the right one is the Shen sign and the left one the Wedjat eye. Additionally, there are nonidentical vertical yellow blank text strips, two on the right side and four on the left side.

The vignette in the center depicts the *hnw* barque of Sokar<sup>35</sup>, symbolizing solar triumphs and the sun's journey through the underworld<sup>36</sup>. According to the pyramid texts, the deceased is raised into Sokar's *hnw* barque, sailing toward dawn or dusk<sup>37</sup>.

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<sup>34</sup> For more: Taylor, J. H., *Ancient Egyptian Book of the Dead: Journey through the afterlife*, London: British Museum Press, 2010, pp. 206-207.

<sup>35</sup> The god Sokar was depicted as either a complete falcon or as a human being with a falcon's head. He is regarded as a god of creation and the underworld. He is regarded as a god of creation and the underworld. His center of worship was the city of Memphis; he was called Lord of Restaw.

Hart, G., *The Routledge Dictionary of Egyptian Gods and Goddesses*, London, 2005, p.148.

#### **2.1.2.3 Third register: (fig. 5-D)**

There are two-winged serpent deities on each side. Each deity has a sun disc atop its head and is stretching its wings. Between the wings stands the Djed pillar, which represents the backbone of the god Osiris. And his residence represents resurrection and renewal<sup>38</sup>.

The Djed pillar is adorned with the crook and flail and is crowned with a double-plumed crown featuring a sun disc. On both sides of the Djed pillar, there are Wedjat eyes. On top of the view, there are vertical yellow blank text strips, three on the right side and four on the left side.

#### **2.1.2.4 Fourth register: (fig. 5-E)**

There are two-winged serpent deities, each featuring a sun disc for a head, positioned on either side, stretching its wings.

Between them, the tit knot, related to the goddess Isis, equally seems to have a protective function<sup>39</sup>. It may also be associated with protecting the fetus in the womb<sup>40</sup>. Note that the fourth register is without any text strips.

#### **2.1.3 Footboard: (fig. 5-F)**

In its center is a blank, vertical yellow strip, presumably designed to be inscribed with the name and title of the deceased, flanked by a pair of seated guardian gods with the heads of hippopotamuses, and in front of their faces is one vertical blank yellow strip, presumably designed to be inscribed with the name of the gods.

The pedestal is painted white (fig. 5-G), and it is also without any decoration.

#### **2.1.4 Back decoration:**

The back of the cartonnage (fig.6) is entirely painted white<sup>41</sup> and does not feature any scenes or texts.

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<sup>36</sup> Whiting, N. E., *The Lost Histories of the Shetayet of Sokar: Contextualizing the Osiris Shaft at Rosetau (Giza) in Archaeological History*, The University of Montana: Missoula, degree of Master, p. 117.

<sup>37</sup> For more: Gaballa. G. A., “New Light on the Cult of Sokar”, *Orientalia* 41/ 2, 1972, p. 178.

<sup>38</sup> Park, R., “The raising of the djed”, *Discussions in Egyptology* 32, 1995, p. 75.

<sup>39</sup> For more: Mohamed, G., “Und das Isis-Blut hat seine Arme in meine Richtung gereicht” in: *Journal of the American Research Center in Egypt* 60, 1, 2024, pp. 227–246.

<sup>40</sup> Wendrich, W., “Entangled, connected or protected? The power of knots and knotting in ancient Egypt in: Szpakowska, K. (ed.), *Through a Glass Darkly: Magic, Dreams, and Prophecy in Ancient Egypt*. Swansea, Wales: The Classical Press of Wales, 2006, p. 250.

<sup>41</sup> According to Egyptian artistic conventions, the color white symbolized purity. It was associated with the linen garments worn by the blessed dead in the afterlife and the mummy

There is a white blank text strip surrounding the back, which includes a central lacing in a cross shape, covered with linen, which is used to close the cartonnage and is partly visible at one end.

This particular method of closure was commonly used for cartonnage during the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty, as in: EA25258<sup>42</sup> and EA22939<sup>43</sup>.



(Fig.6) The back of the cartonnage showing central lacing © Egyptian Museum in Cairo.

## **2.2 Comment on unpublished Cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4**

### **2.2.1 Cartonnage owner:**

Unfortunately, the cartonnage does not include any text indicating the name or title of the coffin's owner.

Additionally, the scenes on the coffin, which reveal the deceased's gender through his appearance and clothing, do not depict him.

It is worth noting, this absence of representation of the deceased may confirm that the coffin was intended for open market.

A comparison of this coffin with other coffins bearing similar scenes reveals that he is presumed to be in the first register behind the falcon-headed god Horus, leading the deceased to Osiris, for example, as in the cartonnage of Paankhenamun at the William M. Willner Fund, 1910.238<sup>44</sup>.

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shroud. White frequently represented the linen wrappings of Osiris, with whom the deceased aspired to join and integrate in the afterlife.

Taylor, Patterns of colouring on ancient Egyptian coffins from the New Kingdom to the Twenty-sixth Dynasty, p. 165.

<sup>42</sup>[https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y\\_EA25258?selectedImageId=161319543](https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA25258?selectedImageId=161319543) accessed: 7/6/2025.

<sup>43</sup>[https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y\\_EA22939?selectedImageId=161319756](https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA22939?selectedImageId=161319756) accessed: 7/6/2025.

<sup>44</sup> <https://www.artic.edu/artworks/64339/coffin-and-mummy-of-paankhaenamun> accessed: 1/8/2025.

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Based on the artistic features on the coffin, such as the black tripartite hair-wig, which is usually used on female coffins, it is likely that the coffin's owner was a woman, although this evidence is not strong, as there are some exceptions in the association of headdresses with the deceased's gender in the Third Intermediate Period. This is also a feature that supports the idea of ready-made coffins for the open market; a woman may wear a man's headdress and vice versa, as the coffins NME 002- NME 004 at the Medelhavsmuseet collection <sup>45</sup>.

### 2.2.2 Cartonnage decorations:

Decorations of cartonnage are carried out by means of a reed pen and black paint. Then, these were filled with different paints: black, white, yellow, red, and green, showing the impact of moisture.

Noting that brushstrokes and color drippings (fig. 7) reveal that this was achieved when the cartonnage stood in a supine position.

The back of the cartonnage (fig. 6) is entirely painted white and does not feature any decorations, probably to reduce the overall cost of the cartonnage. Knowing that the Djed-pillar, a symbol of Osiris, is the likely scene placed along the spine of cartonnages back in that period, with a group of other smaller elements like the Tyet and Ankh symbols.

This can be seen, for example, in Penn Museum cartonnage E14344B<sup>46</sup>, Brooklyn Museum cartonnage 35.1265<sup>47</sup>.



(Fig.7) color drippings indicating a supine position of the cartonnage when the decoration applied  
© Egyptian Museum in Cairo.

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<sup>45</sup> Dodson, A., *Ancient Egyptian Coffins: The Medelhavsmuseet Collection*, Världskulturmuseerna, Göteborg, 2015, p. 28-30.

<sup>46</sup> <https://www.penn.museum/collections/object/326249> accessed: 1/8/2025.

<sup>47</sup> <https://www.brooklynmuseum.org/objects/3357> accessed: 1/8/2025.



### **2.2.3 Cartonnage inscription:**

The cartonnage characterized by blank text strips running along its entire length, but what is interesting and unique about this cartonnage is the presence of only a single recorded word  , Whether on both its front and back surfaces.

In the first register, a vignette depicting Osiris, with Isis positioned behind him and the word   appearing further in the background.

There are two possibilities; the first is that it refers to the goddess Bastet *B3stt*<sup>48</sup>, This form of writing her name appeared in many texts, for example:

-      *sšm n B3stt ḥry-ib(y) W3st* (The bark of Bastet residing in Thebes).<sup>49</sup>
-      *ḥm n B3stt wr ʿ3 ir ḥt n k3.s* (The priest of Bastet, the very great priest, takes care of her ka).<sup>50</sup>

Alternatively, the second possibility is that it refers to a personal name, as the name of the cartonnage's owner. This name appeared as a female personal name from the Middle Kingdom and was written in different forms<sup>51</sup>:  ,  ,  and the form that was recorded on the cartonnage under study  .

So maybe Bastet is the name of the cartonnage owner. However, if that were the case, why wasn't it written on the blank strips on the footboard as is customary?

### **2.2.4 Cartonnage dating:**

The Cartonnage TR. 5.11.16.4 is closer in date to the 22<sup>nd</sup> dynasty, which is based on:

- Taylor divided the decoration of the Theban cartonnage cases into the two main groups, the first type and the second type<sup>52</sup>.
- The cartonnage examined can be classified as (Taylor Type 1)<sup>53</sup>.

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<sup>48</sup> Leitz, Ch., *Lexikon der ägyptischen Götter und Götterbezeichnungen*, vol.2, OLA 111, 2002, p. 739.

<sup>49</sup> Text came from the statue in Berlin Museum (inventory number 17271) Abdel-Raziq, A., "Sacred bark of Bastet" in: *Journal of the General Union of Arab Archaeologists*, 12/1, 2011, p. 6; Lichtheim, M., *Ancient Egyptian literature: A Book of Readings*, vol. III: The Late Period, Berkeley - Los Angeles - London, University of California Press, 1980, p. 32.

<sup>50</sup> Text came from the temple of Horus in Edfu; Abdel-Raziq, Sacred bark of Bastet, p.8.

<sup>51</sup> Ranke, H., *Die Ägyptischen Personennamen. Verzeichnis der Namen*, Vol. 1. Glückstadt: J. J. Augustin. 1935, p. 90.3.

<sup>52</sup> For more: Taylor, J. H., "Theban Coffins from the Twenty-Second to the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty: Dating and Synthesis of Development", In: Strudwick, N., Taylor, J.H. (Eds.), *The Theban Necropolis. Past, Present, and Future*. The British Museum Press, London, 2003, pp. 95–121.

<sup>53</sup> Taylor, *Theban Coffins from the Twenty-Second to the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty*, pl.46.

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- This type is defined by a horizontal arrangement of four to five rectangular compartments, typically containing figures of deities, religious symbols, and vignettes from the Book of the Dead.
- It was utilized during the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty.
- The cartonnage under the study is the most brightly colored element of the coffin set. It was placed inside a black<sup>54</sup> coffin preserved in the basement of the Egyptian Museum in Cairo under inventory number TR. 5.11.16.4C (fig. 8), but unfortunately, the lid was missing.
- A black box (TR. 55.11.16.4C) can be classified as (Taylor design 1), dates to the 22<sup>nd</sup> dynasty<sup>55</sup>, but unfortunately, the lid was missing.
- By comparison, it can be concluded that the missing lid of the black box is made of black painted wood without text or scenes.
- Like the black coffin V.2007.278.1 (fig. 9) in the National Museums Scotland, which dates to the early 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty<sup>56</sup>, or with a gilded face as EA6662 in the British Museum (fig. 10) <sup>57</sup>, if the deceased was from a high social class, but this conflicts with the level of the scenes on the cartonnage, leaving the text strips and its back blank.

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<sup>54</sup> In ancient Egypt, the color black was strongly associated with death and resurrection. Consequently, coffins and other funerary objects were often colored black during various periods. Black decorations or inscriptions were produced exclusively using carbon black derived from organic-fired materials such as soot or charcoal.

Pagès-Camagna, S., Guichard, H. "Coloured materials of Theban coffins produced around the 'yellow coffin' series from the Louvre Collections", in: Amenta, A., Guichard, H., (ed.), *First Vatican Coffin Conference 19-22 June 2013*, vol.1, Vaticano: Edizioni Musei Vaticani, 2017, p. 359.

<sup>55</sup> Taylor, *Theban Coffins from the Twenty-Second to the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty*, pl. 52.

<sup>56</sup> Manley, B., Dodson, A., *Life Everlasting*. National Museums Scotland Collection of Ancient Egyptian Coffins, Edinburgh: NMS Enterprises Ltd., 2010, pp. 56-67.

<https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=664661>

accessed: 7/6/2025.

<sup>57</sup> [https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y\\_EA6662?selectedImageId=406065001](https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA6662?selectedImageId=406065001)

accessed: 8/6/2025.



(Fig.8) cartonnage inside black box (TR. 5.11.16.4C) missing its lid.  
© Egyptian Museum in Cairo.



(Fig.9) lid of comparative black coffin (V.2007.278.1)  
© National Museums Scotland.



(Fig.10) lid of comparative black coffin (EA6662)  
© British Museum.

### 3.Comparison coffins with blank text strips (Table 1)<sup>58</sup>.

| Table 1                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                           |                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Example                                                                                             | Main information                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | place of blank text strips                                                                                                | Owner name                  |
| <div>No.1</div>  | Title: Rishi coffin.<br>Period:2 <sup>nd</sup> Intermediate Period-early New Kingdom.<br>Dynasty: End of 17/early 18 dyn.<br>Provenience: Thebes, El-Assasif.<br>Museum: Metropolitan Museum, MMA excavations, 1915–16.<br>Object Number: 30.3.4 a, b. | The center vertical text strip extends down the center of the body, starting from the bottom of the collar to the ankles. | Owner's name not registered |
|                                                                                                     | Image © Metropolitan Museum<br><a href="https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/546957">https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/546957</a> accessed: 8/6/2025.                                                                         |                                                                                                                           |                             |
| No.2                                                                                                | Title: Rishi coffin                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                           |                             |

<sup>58</sup> The paper avoided deliberately 21st Dynasty coffins because they are characterized by the reuse from earlier periods. This practice also results in blank text strips and has been noted in other references. For more: Fabregat, J. V., *Social Signifiers and Creative Production in the 20th and 21st Dynasties: (Re)Discovering the Individual in Yellow Coffin Decorative Models*, PhD diss., University of Naples Federico, 2024; Cooney, K., *Recycling for Death: Coffin Reuse in Ancient Egypt and the Theban coffin cache*, Cairo: The American University in Cairo Press, 2024.

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|                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                              |                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                           | <p>Period: 2<sup>nd</sup> Intermediate Period-<br/>Early New Kingdom.<br/>Dynasty: End of 17/early 18 dyn.<br/>Provenience: Thebes, El-Assasif.<br/>Museum: Metropolitan Museum.<br/>Object Number: 14.10.1a, b</p>                                                                         | <p>The end of the<br/>vertical strip is blank.</p>                                                                           | <p>Owner's<br/>name not<br/>registered</p> |
| <p>Image © Metropolitan Museum<br/><a href="https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/544783">https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/544783</a> accessed:<br/>8/6/2025.</p> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                              |                                            |
| <p>No.3</p>                                                                                               | <p>Title: Anthropoid Coffin of a<br/>woman<br/>Period: 2<sup>nd</sup> Intermediate Period-<br/>early New Kingdom.<br/>Dynasty: End of 17/early 18 dyn.<br/>Provenience: Thebes.<br/>Material: wood.<br/>Museum: Louver Museum<br/>Object Number: E 22437 - MG<br/>4938</p>                  | <p>The center vertical<br/>text strip starts from<br/>the bottom of the<br/>collar to the ankles.</p>                        | <p>Owner's<br/>name not<br/>registered</p> |
| <p>Image © Louver Museum<br/><a href="https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010005275">https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010005275</a> accessed:<br/>8/6/2025.</p>     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                              |                                            |
| <p>No.4</p>                                                                                             | <p>Title: Anthropoid Coffin of a<br/>woman.<br/>Period: New Kingdom.<br/>Dynasty: Dynasty 18.<br/>Provenience: Sheikh Abd El-<br/>Qurna.<br/>Material: wood<br/>Museum: Metropolitan Museum.<br/>Object Number: 36.3.184</p>                                                                | <p>All the text strips are<br/>blank: one center<br/>vertical text strip and<br/>three horizontal blank<br/>text strips.</p> | <p>Owner's<br/>name not<br/>registered</p> |
| <p>Image © Metropolitan Museum<br/><a href="https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/549021">https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/549021</a> accessed:</p>               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                              |                                            |
| <p>No.5</p>                                                                                             | <p>Title: Anthropoid Coffin of a<br/>woman.<br/>Period: New Kingdom.<br/>Dynasty: New Kingdom reused<br/>by 30th Dynasty or early<br/>Ptolemaic Period.<br/>Provenience: Thebes.<br/>Material: wood.<br/>Museum: Medelhavsmuseet<br/>Collection. National Museums of<br/>World Culture.</p> | <p>The footboard text<br/>strips.</p>                                                                                        | <p>Owner's<br/>name not<br/>registered</p> |

|                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                              | Object Number: MM 13940.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |
|                                                                                              | © The Medelhavsmuseet Collection. National Museums of World Culture.<br><a href="https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3015987">https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3015987</a><br>accessed: 8/6/2025.                                            |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |
| No. 6<br>   | Title: cartonnage fragment.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 22 <sup>nd</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: Linen.<br>Museum: Louvre Museum.<br>Object Number: E 6240.                                                                         | Some of the text strips are blank:<br>(1) the first horizontal Text strips<br>(2) Vertical text strips accompanying the scene.                                       | maybe owner's name registered on the footboard . |
|                                                                                              | Image © Louvre Museum<br><a href="https://collections.louvre.fr/ark:/53355/cl010335904">https://collections.louvre.fr/ark:/53355/cl010335904</a> accessed: 8/6/2025.                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |
| No.7<br>   | Title: cartonnage coffin of a man (Nesperennub), but designed for a Woman.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 22 <sup>nd</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: cartonnage.<br>Museum: British Museum.<br>Object Number: EA30720                    | Some of the text strips are blank:<br>(1) The right side of the first row<br>(2) The horizontal text strips<br>(3) Some vertical text strips accompanying the scene. | Owner's name registered on the footboard         |
|                                                                                              | Image © British Museum<br><a href="https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA30720?selectedImageId=98700001">https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA30720?selectedImageId=98700001</a><br>accessed: 8/6/2025.                                            |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |
| No. 8<br> | Title: cartonnage coffin of a man but contained a mummified teenage female.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 22 <sup>nd</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: cartonnage.<br>Museum: National Museums Scotland.<br>Object Number: A.1911.399.1 B | All of the text strips are blank:<br>(1) Vertical text accompanying the scenes<br>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes<br>(3) footboard text strips.               | Owner's name not registered                      |
|                                                                                              | Image © National Museums Scotland<br><a href="https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=299943">https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=299943</a>                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                  |



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|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| accessed: 22/7/2025.                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                            |                                    |
| No.9<br>    | Title: cartonnage coffin.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 22 <sup>nd</sup> Dynasty; 25 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: glued fabric, plant fiber.<br>Museum: Louvre Museum.<br>Object Number: E 13022.                                               | All the text strips are blank:<br>(1) the vertical text accompanying the scenes<br>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes.                                                 | Owner's name not registered        |
|                                                                                              | © Louvre Museum<br><a href="https://collections.louvre.fr/ark:/53355/cl010335899">https://collections.louvre.fr/ark:/53355/cl010335899</a> accessed: 22/7/2025.                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                            |                                    |
| No.10<br>  | Title: coffin fragment.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 25 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: Wood.<br>Museum: Swansea Museum.<br>Object Number: In storage (EC364)                                                                                     | All the text strips are blank:<br>(1) horizontal Text strip between the scenes.<br>(2) the Vertical text accompanying the scenes.                                          | Owner's name not registered        |
|                                                                                              | © Swansea Museum (The Egypt Centre).<br><a href="https://egyptcentre.abasetcollections.com/Objects/Details/5079?Save&amp;dSelections=\$Search-coffin\$Page-2">https://egyptcentre.abasetcollections.com/Objects/Details/5079?Save&amp;dSelections=\$Search-coffin\$Page-2</a> accessed: 22/7/2025. |                                                                                                                                                                            |                                    |
| No.11<br> | Title: Anthropoid Coffin.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 25 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: Wood.<br>Museum: National Museums Liverpool.<br>Object Number: 39.4042.5b                                                                               | All the text strips in the lid are blank:<br>(1) Vertical text accompanying the scenes.<br>(2) horizontal Text strip between the scenes.<br>(3) center vertical text strip | Owner's name registered on the box |
|                                                                                              | Image © National Museums Liverpool<br><a href="https://www.liverpoolmuseums.org.uk/artifact/coffin-lid-of-haty">https://www.liverpoolmuseums.org.uk/artifact/coffin-lid-of-haty</a> accessed: 22/7/2025.                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                            |                                    |
| No.12                                                                                        | Title: Anthropoid Coffin of a woman (Tadiaset).<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period /Late period.<br>Dynasty: 25-26 Dynasty.                                                                                                                                                                      | Some of the text strips are blank:<br>(1) the Vertical text accompanying the scenes in the first row.                                                                      | Owner's name registered more than  |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                | <p>Provenience: Thebes.<br/>Material: Wood.<br/>Museum: Egizio Museum, Turin.<br/>Object Number: Suppl. 5244.</p>                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                        | <p>once</p>                                     |
| <p>Image © Egizio Museo <a href="#">Collection online - Lid of the coffin of Tadiaset-taheket</a><br/>accessed: 4/6/2025.</p>                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |
| <p>No.13</p>                                                                                                   | <p>Title: Single anthropoid coffin of a man (Bakrenes), a lower elite.<br/>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br/>/Late Period.<br/>Dynasty: 25 – 26 Dynasty.<br/>Provenience: Sheikh Abd El Qurna.<br/>Material: Wood.<br/>Museum: British Museum<br/>Object Number: EA15654</p> | <p>Some of the text strips are blank:<br/>(1) the Vertical text accompanying the scenes<br/>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes</p> | <p>Owner's name registered on the footboard</p> |
| <p>Image © The British Museum<br/><a href="https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA15654">https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA15654</a><br/>accessed: 4/8/2025.</p> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |
| <p>No.14</p>                                                                                                 | <p>Title: outer coffin of Isetirdis.<br/>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br/>/ Late Period.<br/>Dynasty: 25 – 26 Dynasty.<br/>Provenience: Thebes.<br/>Material: wood.<br/>Museum: Museum in Stockholm, Sweden (Medelhavsmuseet collection)<br/>Object Number:</p>             | <p>Some of the text strips are blank:<br/>(1) the Vertical text accompanying the scenes<br/>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes</p> | <p>Owner's name registered</p>                  |
| <p>Image © Dodson, A., <i>Ancient Egyptian coffins: the Medelhavsmuseet collection</i>, 2015, cat. 13, p. 33.</p>                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |
| <p>No.15</p>                                                                                                 | <p>Title: outer coffin of Amenhotepiyn.<br/>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br/>Dynasty: 25<sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br/>Provenience: Thebes.<br/>Material: wood.<br/>Museum: National Museums Scotland.<br/>Object Number: A.1869.33A.</p>                                       | <p>The blank text strips are:<br/>(1) the vertical text accompanying the scenes<br/>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes</p>         | <p>Owner's name registered</p>                  |
| <p>Image © National Museums Scotland</p>                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                               | <a href="https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=404922">https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=404922</a> accessed: 22/7/2025.                                           |                                                                                                                                                           |                                                |
| No.16<br>    | Title: inner coffin of Amenhotepiyin.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 25 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: wood.<br>Museum: National Museums Scotland.<br>Object Number: A.1869.33C.                     | The blank text strips are:<br>(1) the vertical text accompanying the scenes.<br>(2) horizontal Text between the scenes.                                   | Owner's name registered                        |
|                                                                                               | Image © National Museums Scotland<br><a href="https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=404923">https://www.nms.ac.uk/search-our-collections/collection-search-results?entry=404923</a> accessed: 4/6/2025.       |                                                                                                                                                           |                                                |
| No.17<br>   | Title: Anthropoid Coffin of a man (Pakepu).<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 25 <sup>th</sup> – 26 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: wood.<br>Museum: The Fitzwilliam Museum.<br>Object Number: E.2.1869. | The blank text strips are:<br>(1) the vertical text accompanying the scenes                                                                               | Owner's name registered                        |
|                                                                                               | Image © The Fitzwilliam Museum<br><a href="https://fitzmuseum.cam.ac.uk/learn-with-us/look-think-do/the-coffin-set-of-pakepu">https://fitzmuseum.cam.ac.uk/learn-with-us/look-think-do/the-coffin-set-of-pakepu</a> accessed: 4/6/2025.              |                                                                                                                                                           |                                                |
| No. 18<br> | Title: inner coffin of Dismutenibtes.<br>Period: Third Intermediate Period.<br>Dynasty: 25 <sup>th</sup> Dynasty.<br>Provenience: Thebes.<br>Material: wood.<br>Museum: Oslo Museum.<br>Object Number: (C47708)                                      | Some of the text strips are blank:<br>(1) The vertical text accompanying the scenes.<br>(2) Horizontal text between the scene rows.<br>(3) The footboard. | Owner's name registered on the footboard sides |
|                                                                                               | Image © Bettum, A., “Dismutenibtes and Aaiu. Two 25th Dynasty Coffins in Oslo”, <i>Studien zur Altägyptischen Kultur</i> , vol. 39, 2010, fig. 5.                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                           |                                                |
| No. 19<br> | Title: Coffin fragments.<br>Period: Greco-Roman Period<br>Provenience: Thebes?                                                                                                                                                                       | The vertical text                                                                                                                                         | Owner's                                        |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                            |                                            |                             |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Material: wood.<br>Museum: Boston Museum<br>Object Number: 1989.74-77.                                                                                     | accompanying the scenes.                   | name not registered         |
| Image © Boston Museum.<br><a href="https://collections.mfa.org/objects/164627/coffin-panel-boat-procession-and-introduction-to-the-funer?ctx=38e91bb4-a253-43d3-b4d9-068569cc3998&amp;idx=29">https://collections.mfa.org/objects/164627/coffin-panel-boat-procession-and-introduction-to-the-funer?ctx=38e91bb4-a253-43d3-b4d9-068569cc3998&amp;idx=29</a><br>accessed: 4/8/2025. |                                                                                                                                                            |                                            |                             |
| No. 20<br>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Title: Coffin fragment.<br>Period: Greco-Roman Period<br>Provenience: Thebes?<br>Material: wood.<br>Museum: Medelhavsmuseet.<br>Object Number: MM 13943.   | The vertical text accompanying the scenes. | Owner's name not registered |
| Image © Medelhavsmuseet<br><a href="https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3016088">https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3016088</a><br>accessed: 4/8/2025.                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                            |                                            |                             |
| No. 21<br>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Title: Coffin fragment.<br>Period: Greco-Roman Period<br>Provenience: Thebes?<br>Material: wood.<br>Museum: Museum of Fine Arts.<br>Object Number: 98.5-E. | The vertical text accompanying the scenes. | Owner's name not registered |
| Image © the Museum of Fine Arts<br><a href="https://www.mfab.hu/artworks/13356/">https://www.mfab.hu/artworks/13356/</a> accessed: 4/8/2025.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                            |                                            |                             |

### 3.1 Comment on Table. 1:

- 3.1.1** The phenomenon of blank text strips on coffins during the Third Intermediate Period did not originate in that era; rather, it has been present at least since the end of the Second Intermediate Period.
- This is supported by several examples of coffins that feature blank text strips running along their length as (Table. 1- no. 1,3,4).
- In some cases, these coffins were pre-made with a vertical strip of inscription down the center of the lid that asks that Ptah and Osiris give royal offerings to the ka of the deceased, but the space designated for the deceased's name was left blank in anticipation of the eventual owner. For some reason, this name was

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never recorded, even after the coffin had been sold and used for burial, as (Table. 1- no. 2) in which the mummy of a woman was found inside it.

- 3.1.2** The reasons why some coffins featured blank strips continued to exist until the Greco-Roman period (Table. 1- no. 19, 20, 21).  
The most significant of these reasons was the availability of workshops that produced and stored ready-made coffins for sale.
- 3.1.3** The sale process may be completed and actually used for burial with a blank text strips and without the deceased's name written on it, as in (Table. 1-no. 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10).
- 3.1.4** When ready-made coffins are sold, the last step involves allocating them to their owner. This is done by writing the owner's name and title in hieratic script, but in most cases, the mother's and father's names are not included.
- 3.1.5** In this case, the one who wrote it is not a specialized writer but rather most likely the artist who was present in the workshop at the time of the sale.
- 3.1.6** As for the place where the name and title of the deceased are:  
(a) In the usual place, the middle strips of the footboard as in (Table. 1- no. 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17).  
(b) In the side strips of the footboard, leaving the middle strips empty as in (Table.1- no.18).  
(c) The text strips of the lid are left completely blank, and the name is recorded on the box only as in (Table. 1- no. 11).
- 3.1.7** In ready-made coffins, which are easily identified by their blank text strips, the artistic features of the coffin may not match the gender of the deceased.  
A coffin designed for a woman may have buried inside it a man, as in the cartonnage (EA30720) in the British Museum from Thebes dating to the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty (Table. 1- no. 7); it's a cartonnage case possibly designed for a woman but inscribed with the name of a man, Nesperennub<sup>59</sup>.  
Or vice versa, as (Table.1- no. 8) in cartonnage (A.1911.399.1 B)<sup>60</sup> in National Museums Scotland, from Thebes dating to the 22<sup>nd</sup> Dynasty, it's a cartonnage case possibly designed for a man but contained a mummified teenage female.

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<sup>59</sup> The Nesperennub's titles are opener of the two gates of Karnak and libationer of the temple of Khons at Karnak; for more: Strudwick, N., *Masterpieces of Ancient Egypt*, London: The British Museum Press, 2006, p. 254-255.

<sup>60</sup> Dawson, W. R., "On Two Egyptian Mummies Preserved in the Museums of Edinburgh" in: *Proceedings of the Society of Antiquaries of Scotland*, vol.61, 1927, pp. 290-96; Manley, B., Dodson, A., *Life Everlasting*, Cat. 21, pp. 69-70.

- 3.1.8** Although the text strips are blank, it is possible to deduce what was written on them by comparison. For example, in (Table.1- no. 4), the texts that were supposed to be recorded but did not occur are likely similar to those from the Coffin of Harmose (MMA 36.3.172a, b)<sup>61</sup>, which dates to the same period (New Kingdom) and the same place (Thebes, Sheikh Abd al-Qurna).
- 3.1.9** In some cases of reuse of New Kingdom coffins, despite a clear effort to reshape some parts of the coffin to match the features and characteristics prevalent in the Third Intermediate Period, the coffins were left without the names of their new owners, as in (Table. 1- no. 5)<sup>62</sup>. Although the feet have been extensively reworked to change them from the form current during the New Kingdom to the pedestalled form that first appears under Takelot III and continues into Roman times, tenon sockets indicate that the outer parts of the feet were provided in separate pieces <sup>63</sup>.
- 3.1.10** Some inner coffins and cartonnage, which were less visible, included one or more blank text strips alongside the strip with text in the same register as (Table. 1- no. 6, 7). The inconsistencies in the inscriptions suggest a hurried or careless process, which could indicate that the scribe was under pressure due to the large number of pieces and the high demand for them. This raises questions about the overall quality control in the production of such significant artifacts.
- 3.1.11** Not all unknown coffins had blank text strips. Some coffins included text strips but without the owner's name recorded, or without leaving a blank space for that name, which is usually recorded at the time of sale. Note that most of these examples date back to the Twenty-first Dynasty, such as NME 893a<sup>64</sup> and NME 890<sup>65</sup>, MM 90.6.120 <sup>66</sup>.
- 3.1.12** In quite a few cartonnages as seen in the examples (Table.1- no.6, 7) and wooden coffins as seen in the examples (Table. 1 - no. 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17). The text strips are in a semi-complete state; the name of the owner and most other texts have already been recorded. However, the accompanying text strips of the gods' scene are left blank, which represents the most text strips left blank. This absence may be attributed to the mere presence of these engraved deities without the need to write their names.

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<sup>61</sup> <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/549020> accessed: 4/8/2025.

<sup>62</sup> Manley, B., Dodson, A., *Life Everlasting*, Cat. 33, p. 102.

<https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3015987> accessed: 4/8/2025.

<sup>63</sup> Dodson, *Ancient Egyptian Coffins: The Medelhavsmuseet collection*, pp. 10-11.

<sup>64</sup> <https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3979146> accessed: 4/8/2025.

<sup>65</sup> Dodson, *Ancient Egyptian Coffins*, p. 13-15; Niwinski, A., *21st Dynasty Coffins from Thebes*, 1988, p. 162.

<https://collections.smvk.se/carlotta-mhm/web/object/3015856> accessed: 8/7/2025.

<sup>66</sup> <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/552622> accessed: 4/8/2025.



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- 3.1.13** Most Third Intermediate Period coffins with complete or limited blank text strips consist of cartonnage and inner coffins.
- 3.1.14** For outer coffins, the blank strips typically accompany scenes of the gods<sup>67</sup>, but their names are not inscribed, as seen in the examples (Table.1- no., 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17).
- 3.1.15** The economic reason and the lack of libraries to pay the writer's fee are not the only reasons for using coffins in burials with blank text strips.
- 3.1.16** According to (Table.1) the quality does not depend only on whether the coffin was made to somebody's order or not; there are coffins of high-quality decoration, that were prepared in advance, before the name and titles of the deceased had been known to the craftsmen. It seems that the price played an essential role in such situations. The coffins of higher quality were undoubtedly more expensive.

### **4. Conclusion:**

After studying, comparing, and analyzing, the paper concluded that:

#### **4.1 The presence of blank text strips on the Third Intermediate Period Theban coffins indicates the following possibilities:**

If blank text strips extend along the length of the coffin, regardless of whether the owner's name appears on the footboard, the following interpretations can be made:

- a) The coffin was likely produced for the open market.
- b) The coffin was not manufactured specifically for the individual owner.
- c) Another specialist, mostly a scribe, may have participated in the decoration of the coffin as a last step before the sale.
- d) Filling blank text strips would of course increase the price of the coffin.

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<sup>67</sup> This feature, characterized by the absence of the names of the gods on their strips despite the texts being complete, is also observed in some stelae from the Third Intermediate Period, such as: N3387 and N 3943 in the Louvre Museum.

For more: Munro, P., *Die spätägyptischen Totenstelen*, *Ägyptologische Forschungen* 25, 1973, p. 193, pl. 3; <https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010014152>; accessed: 4/8/2025; <https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010014469>. accessed: 4/8/2025.

#### **4.2 Theban Coffins with blank Text Strips Classification:**

**Group 1:** Coffins have completely blank text strips running extending along their length without a name or title identifying their owner.

Possible reasons: economic constraints, workshop practices, scribal issues, or an urgent need.

**Group 2:** Coffins have blank strips running extending along their length, with the exception of the footboard, which contains text strips displaying the owner's name and title.

Possible reasons: economic constraints, workshop practices, or an urgent need.

**Group 3:** Coffins have a semi-complete text strip; the name of the owner and most other texts have already been recorded.

**Group 3a:** Only the accompanying text strips of the god's scene are left blank.

Possible reason: religious considerations.

**Group 3b:** Only the filler or divider strips between coffin rows are left blank.

Possible reason: decorative considerations.

#### **4.3 Potential Reasons for Blank Text Strips on Theban coffins:**

Noting that more than one reason may come together.

| <b>Reason</b>              | <b>Explanation</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Economic constraints       | Buyers with limited funds chose cheaper coffins without full inscriptions; this could reflect the buyer's economic status, where the full customization of the coffin, including the addition of inscriptions, was beyond their means. |
| Urgent need                | Sudden death or lack of time prevented full inscription.                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Workshop practices         | Coffins are produced as stock items to be personalized after purchase.                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Scribal issues             | Incomplete work by scribes, especially with inner coffins, which could indicate that the scribe was under pressure due to the large number of pieces and the high demand for them.                                                     |
| Religious considerations   | It is sufficient to depict the formal form of the goddess.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Decorative considerations. | These objects were likely created for aesthetic and decorative purposes. The use of the blank text strips may have been intentional.                                                                                                   |

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### 4.4 Coffin Sales Methods in the Third Intermediate Period:

#### a) A custom coffin:

The coffin was completed at the time of sale, and many details were likely selected by its owner beforehand. The deceased's title and name were carefully inscribed in several places between the texts and on the coffin's footboard.

#### b) A non-custom coffin:

The coffin was an unfinished product at the time of sale. These are characterized, among others, by the blank text strips and also brief inscriptions of the deceased's title and name, occasionally seen with hieratic written in black ink on the footboard.

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